

Perspectives on business development

BU5300 – IT Project Management

David Coates, January 16th, 2026

David Coates

Lecturer/Study Program Leader

- born & raised in Canada/emigrated to Norway (Berrrrrgen)
- Architecture degree from Carleton University/Algonquin College, Ottawa
- study program manager for BIF and MIN
- active in various start-up environments (gründer in 3, on number 4+5)
- research areas- design/architecture, “ageing in place”, service innovation, creativity, environmental psychology, entrepreneurship...



The short story

Designing a business case

- Entrepreneurship is a process (**trust the process!**)
- Define the problem (to solve) before defining the idea (to solve it)
- Users/customers have trouble *articulating* the problem (like a child)
- End users is not always the customer (and the stakeholders can be more important than you think!)
- The better the problem definition, the better the solution (the better the product <-> market fit)
- Think like a user

BU5300- IT Project Management

Project (the idea) + Management (leadership)

LEADERSHIP (and learning how to pivot when things go wrong)

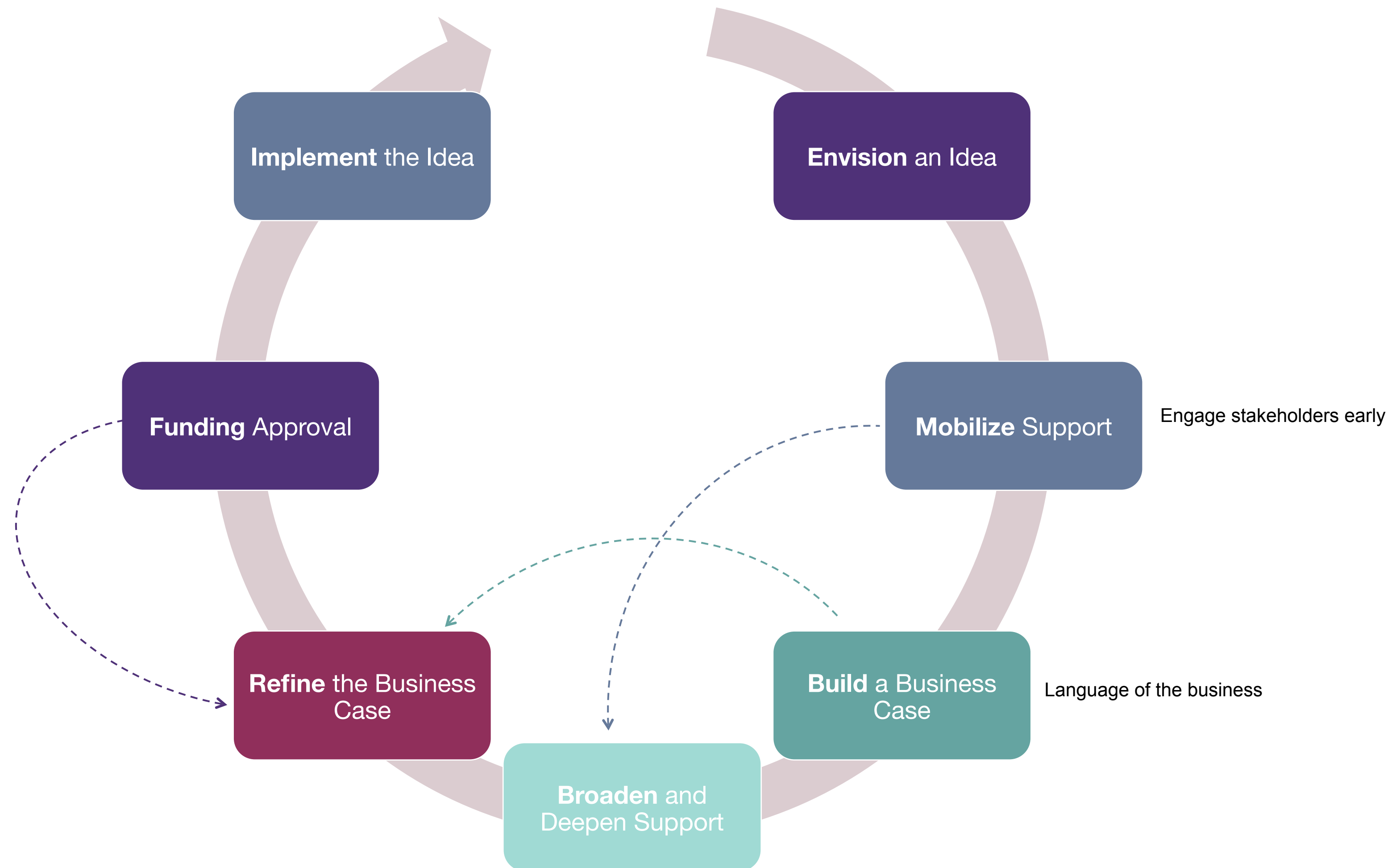
A definition:

“A business case provides **justification** for undertaking a project, programme or portfolio. It **evaluates** the **benefit, cost and risk of alternative options** and provides a **rationale** for the preferred solution.”

Murray-Webster, Ruth. 2019. **APM Body of Knowledge. 7th edition.** Princes Risborough: Association for Project Management.

The Innovation Cycle

from envisioning to implementing (an idea)



Product innovation



Process innovation



Business model innovation



The Entrepreneurial Cycle

From understanding of the problem to a solution for the user (Design Thinking)

1. Understanding

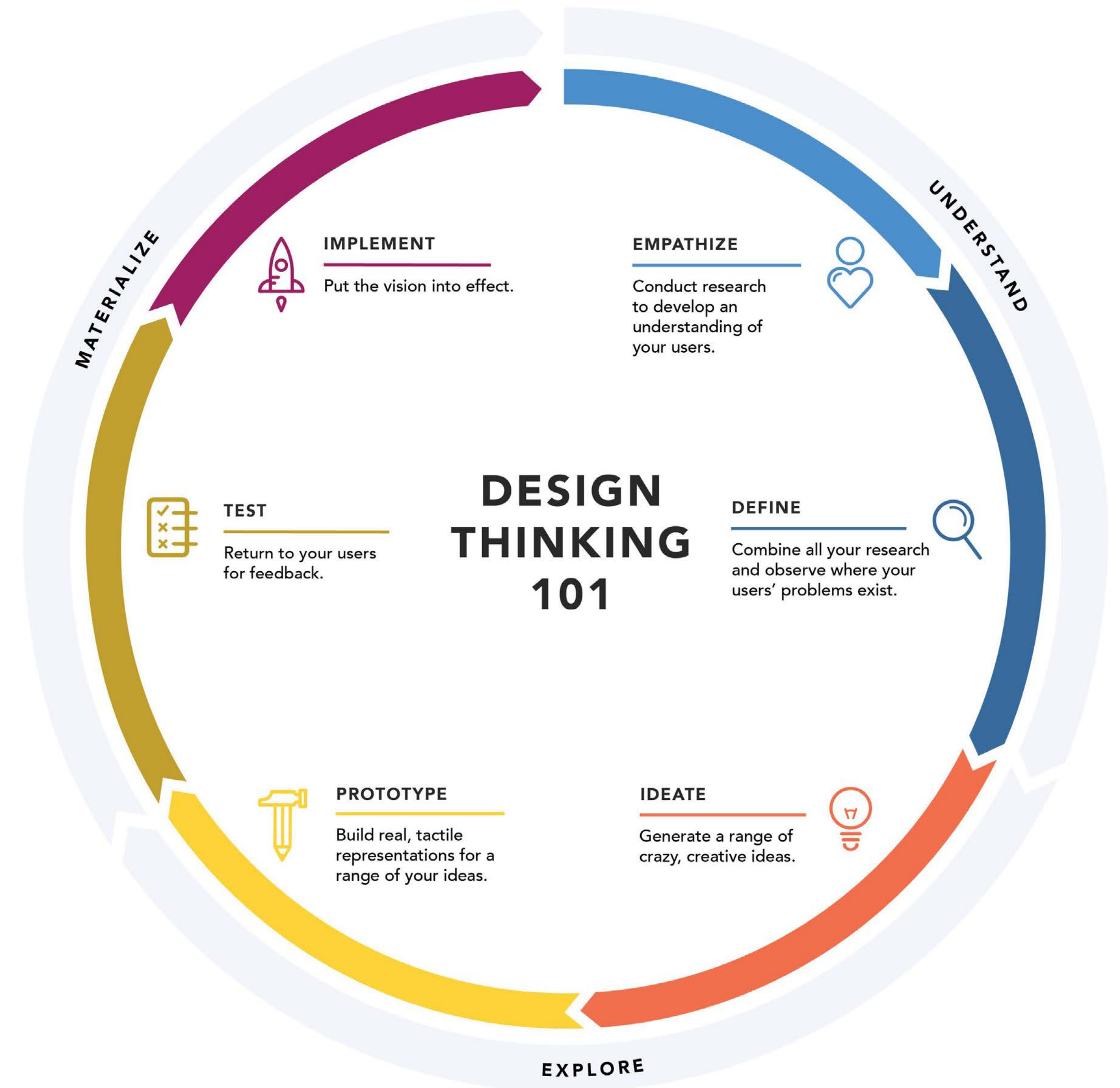
- **Empathise**- understanding the user
- **Define**- what is the “job to be done”

2. Exploring

- **Ideate**- generate ideas -> solve the problem
- **Prototype**- build real idea “sketches”

3. Materializing

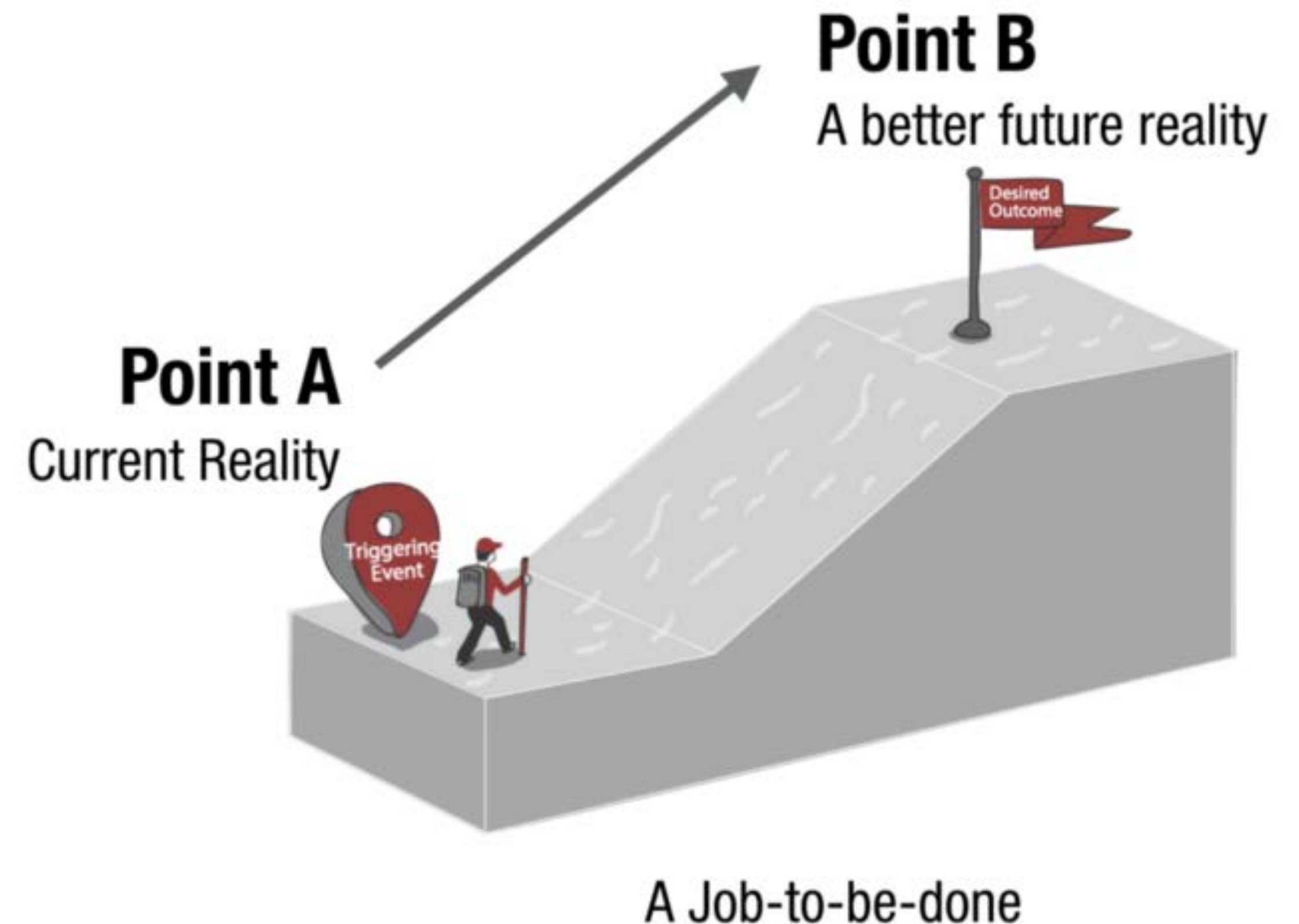
- **Test**- talk to the real users- does it work?
- **Implement**- your vision/solution in action



Think like an entrepreneur

Building solid business cases

- **listen** to the users, **observe** their problems/patterns, **validate** their problems
- **define** the “**jobs to be done**” (better? different? faster? safer? etc...)
- **define** how your solution **generates value for the customer** (not for you)



Think like an entrepreneur

Building solid business cases

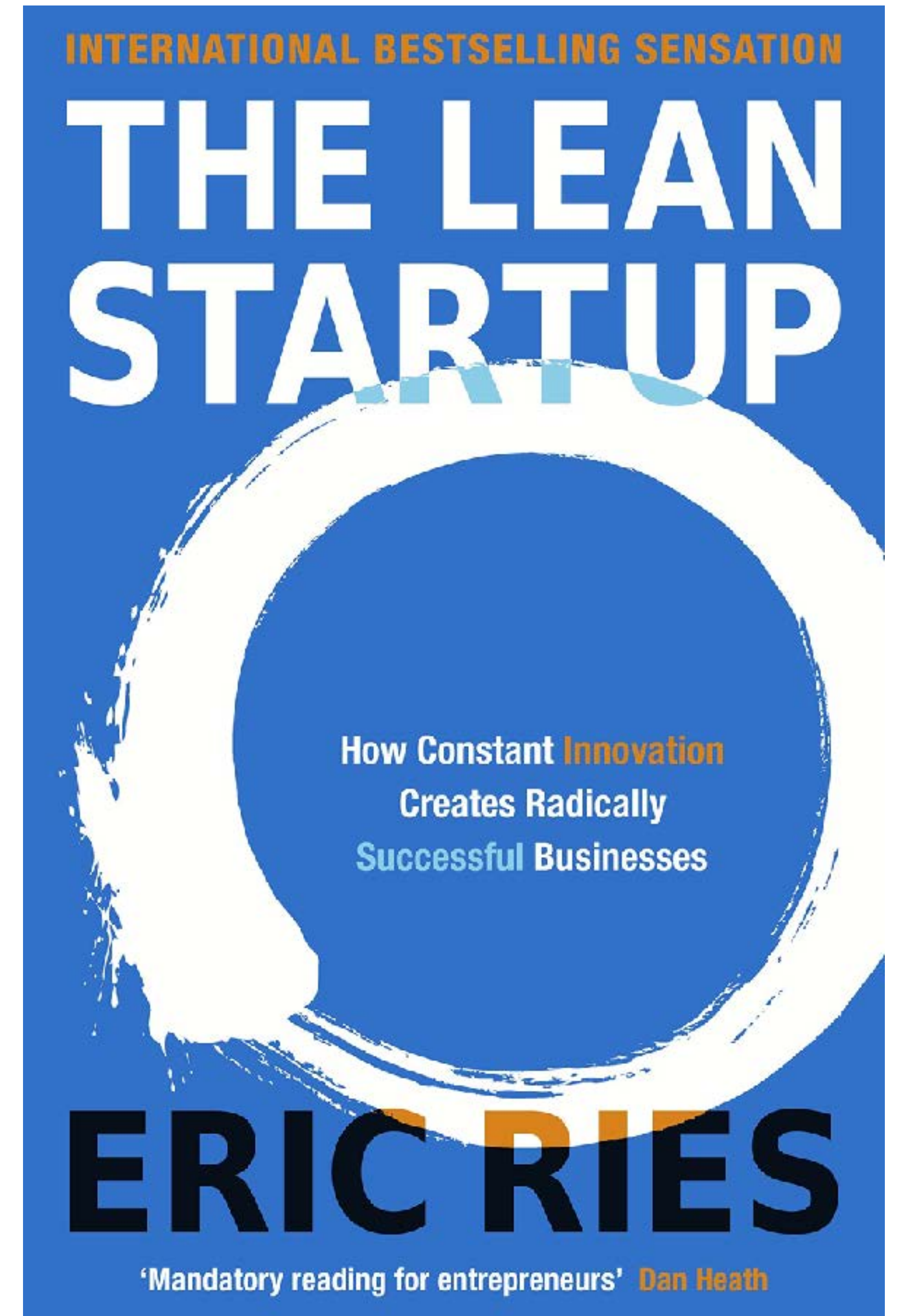
- **generate** ideas that solve the problems and **validate** them with the customer
- **define** a direction/solution and **build quick prototypes early** and **test** them **often**
- **ITERATE** (do it again but change one small thing)
- all the while *making a plan, setting deadlines, mapping new options, pivoting, staying agile, flexible and responsive to the users*



The Lean Start up

Why new ideas fail

- “Entrepreneurship is management... management specifically geared to its context of extreme uncertainty.”
- “Validated learning-learn by running frequent experiments that allow entrepreneurs to test each element of their vision.”
- “the allure of a good plan, a solid strategy, and thorough market research.”



Be prepared to be wrong (and fail)
before you get it right

dyson
FAILED

5126

“The key to success is failure... Success is made of 99 percent failure.”

What comes first? The problem? Or the idea?



“People don't want to buy an 8mm drill,
they want to buy an 8mm hole.”

–THEODORE LEVITT, CITED IN: CLAYTON CHRISTENSEN (2016)

"JOBS TO BE DONE"

–Anthony Ulwik/Clayton Christensen (2003)



People don't just buy your product
they **hire it** to get a job done.

THEY FIRE IT, IF IT DOESN'T.

CLAY CHRISTENSEN,
Harvard Business School
"The Innovator's Dilemma"



Enabling Great Entrepreneurs to
Build Great Companies.



30
Companies built



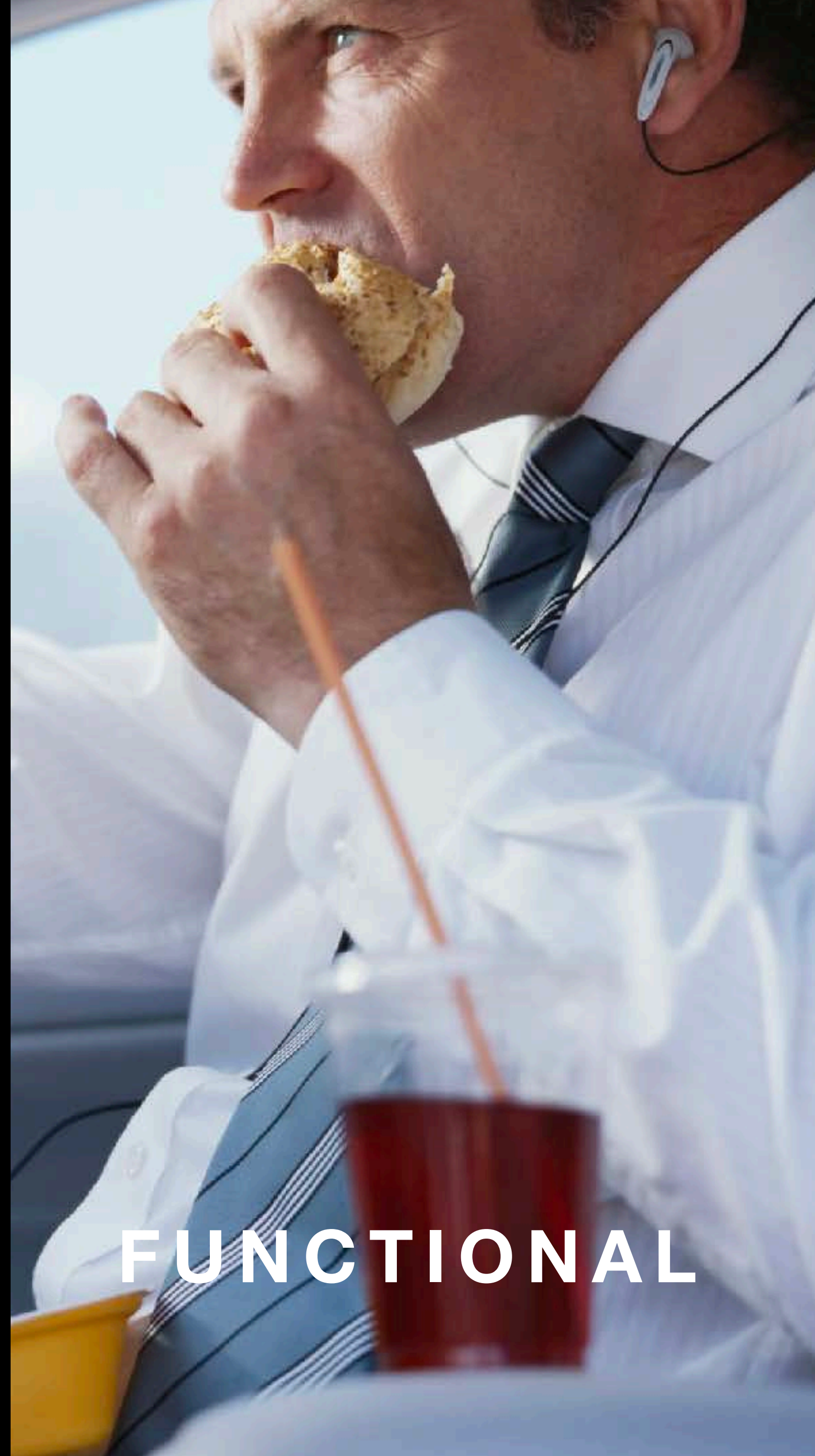
2.000.000
Annual custommers



2000
Colleagues



3 billion NOK
Annual revenue



FUNCTIONAL



SOCIAL



EMOTIONAL

Starbucks



Uber



Gjensidig



3 types of jobs (you “hire” products for)

What makes you buy/hire what you do?

1. FUNCTIONAL Jobs

- tasks or problems the customer wants to complete/solve
- eg.: wash your hair, keep warm on a winter's day, get from A to B.

2. SOCIAL Jobs

- the customer wants to look good or gain power. Social jobs can change how others perceive them.
- eg.: a new suit helps you to fit into a new job or a new environment

3. EMOTIONAL Jobs

- how others perceive the customer/how a customer feels about him/herself
 - eg.: buy something to feel more confident, to feel acknowledged or to improve their happiness/self esteem.

"In the factory we make cosmetics; in the store
we sell hope"

— Charles Revson, founder of Revlon



Value Proposition Design

Alexander Osterwalder

You're holding more than a book,
it's the first step to design, test and deliver
what really matters for your customers.

Value Proposition Design

By Alex Osterwalder, Yves Pigneur,
Greg Bernarda, & Alan Smith
Designed by Trish Papadakos



Hvordan skape
produkter og tjenester
som kundene vil ha

Vinnende verdiforslag

Skrevet av
Alex Osterwalder
Yves Pigneur
Greg Bernarda
Alan Smith

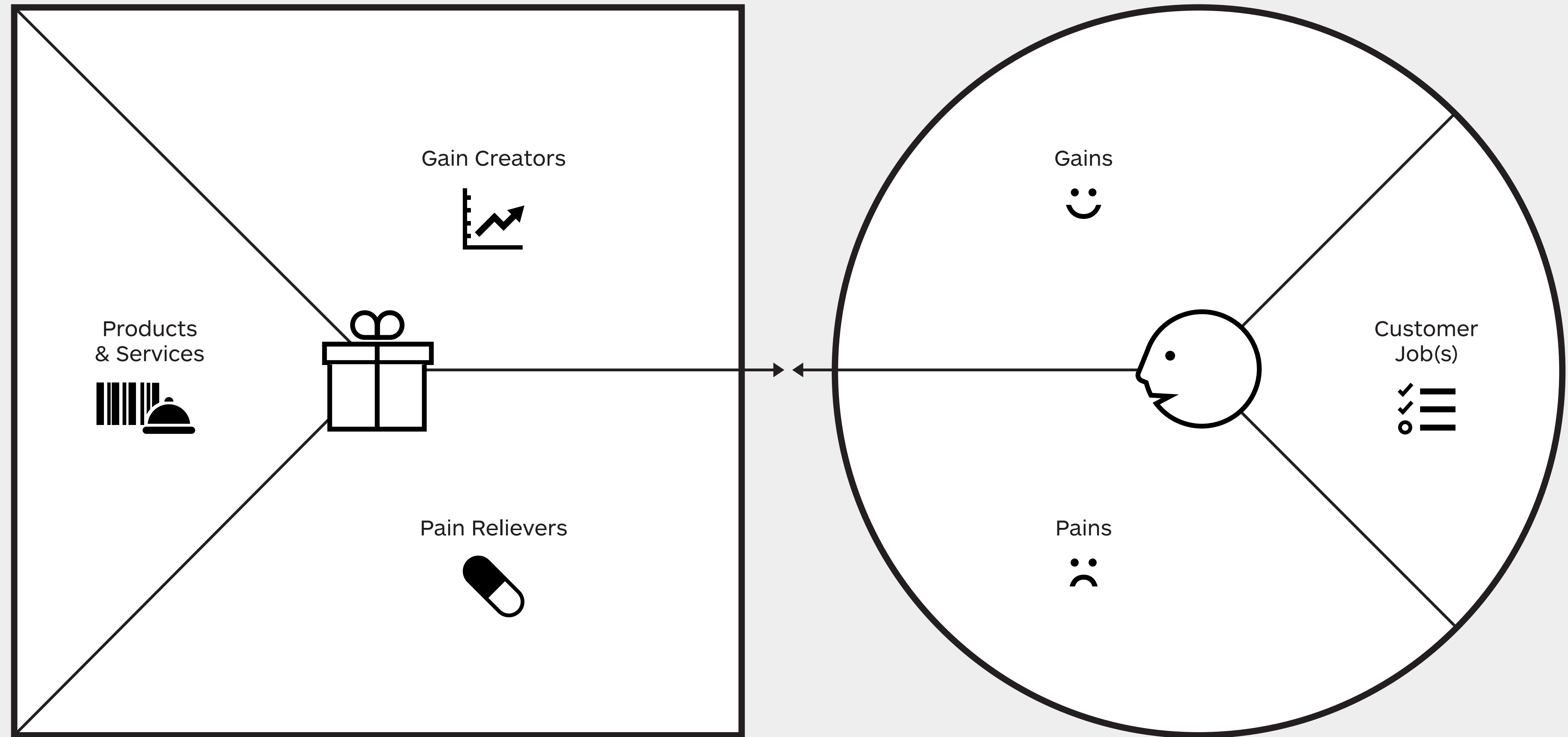
Design og layout av
Trish Papadakos

GRUNNLAG
AV
STRATEGYZER

VERDIFORSLAG
AV
STRATEGYZER



Value Proposition Canvas:



The target group (The customer who needs your value)

Gains

- positive outcomes
- results, benefits, ambitions

Gains measure
for a job well
done



Customer Jobs

What tasks can the customer complete (with your product)?



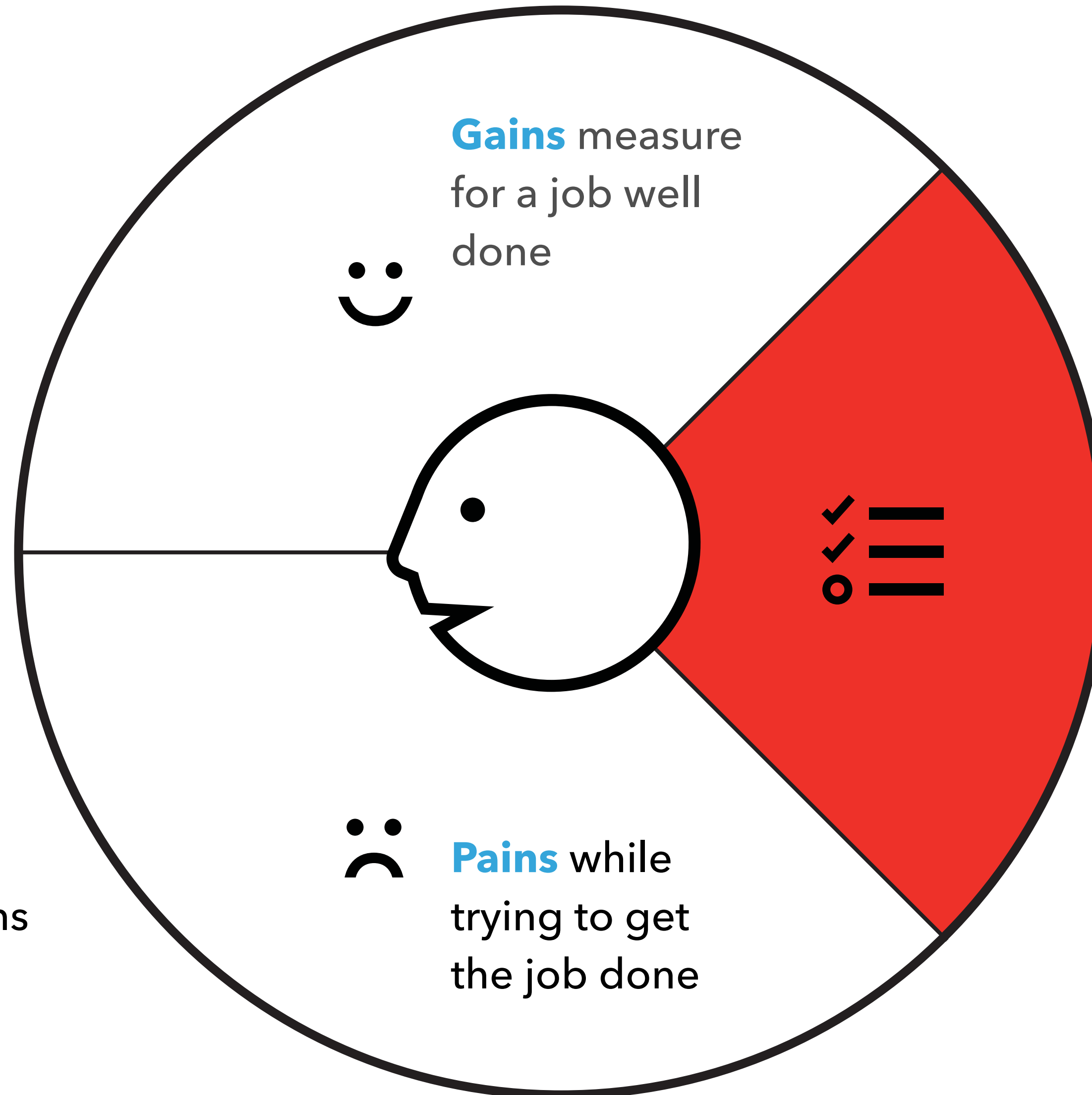
- functional
- social
- emotional

Pains

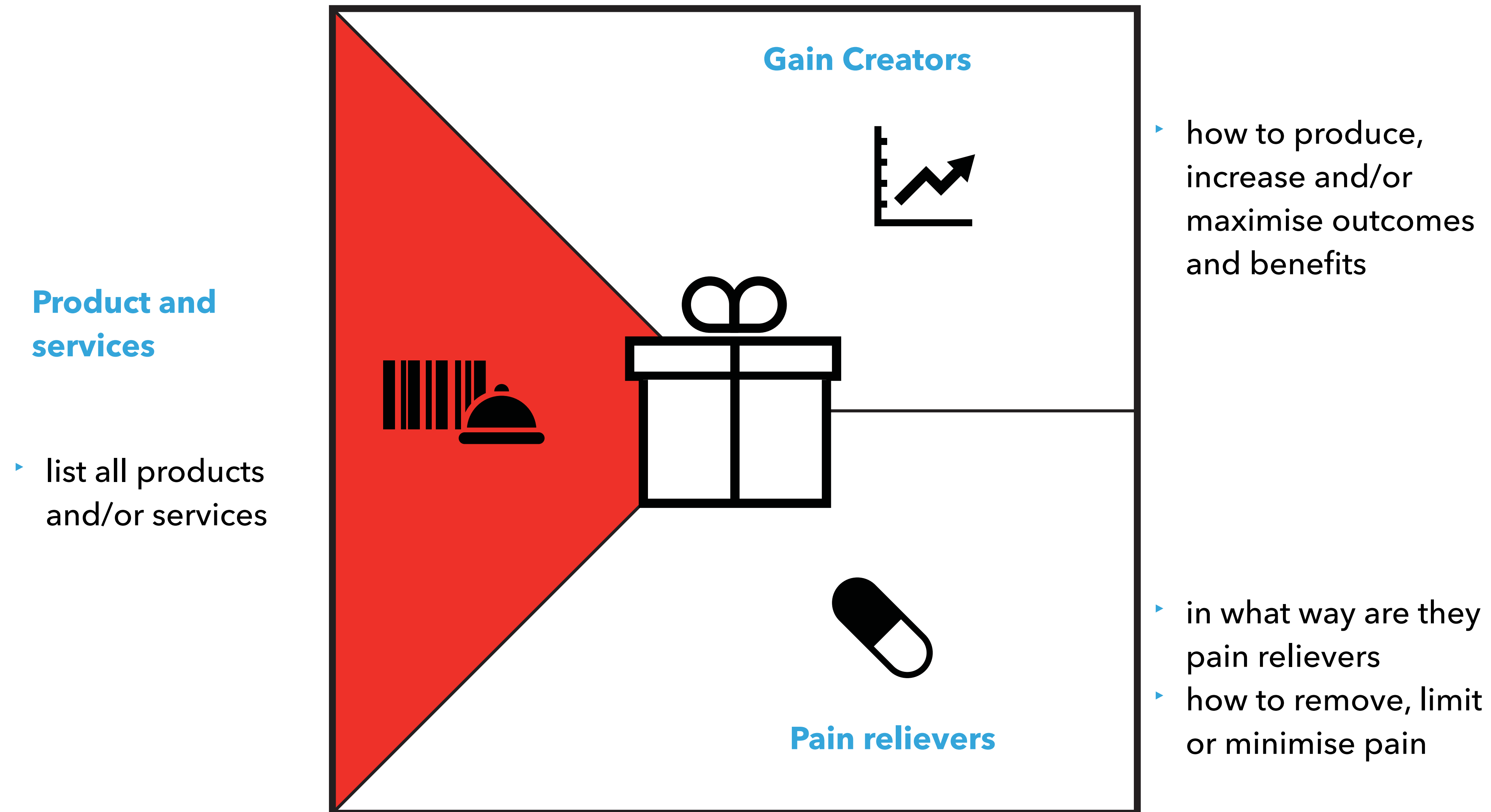
- negative outcomes
- poor existing solutions
- frustrations, risks, obstacles



Pains while
trying to get
the job done



Products and services (what the value is built on)

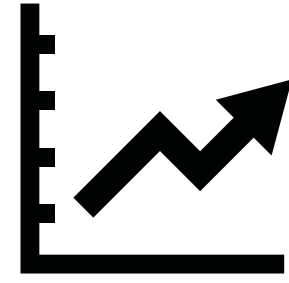


Pain relievers

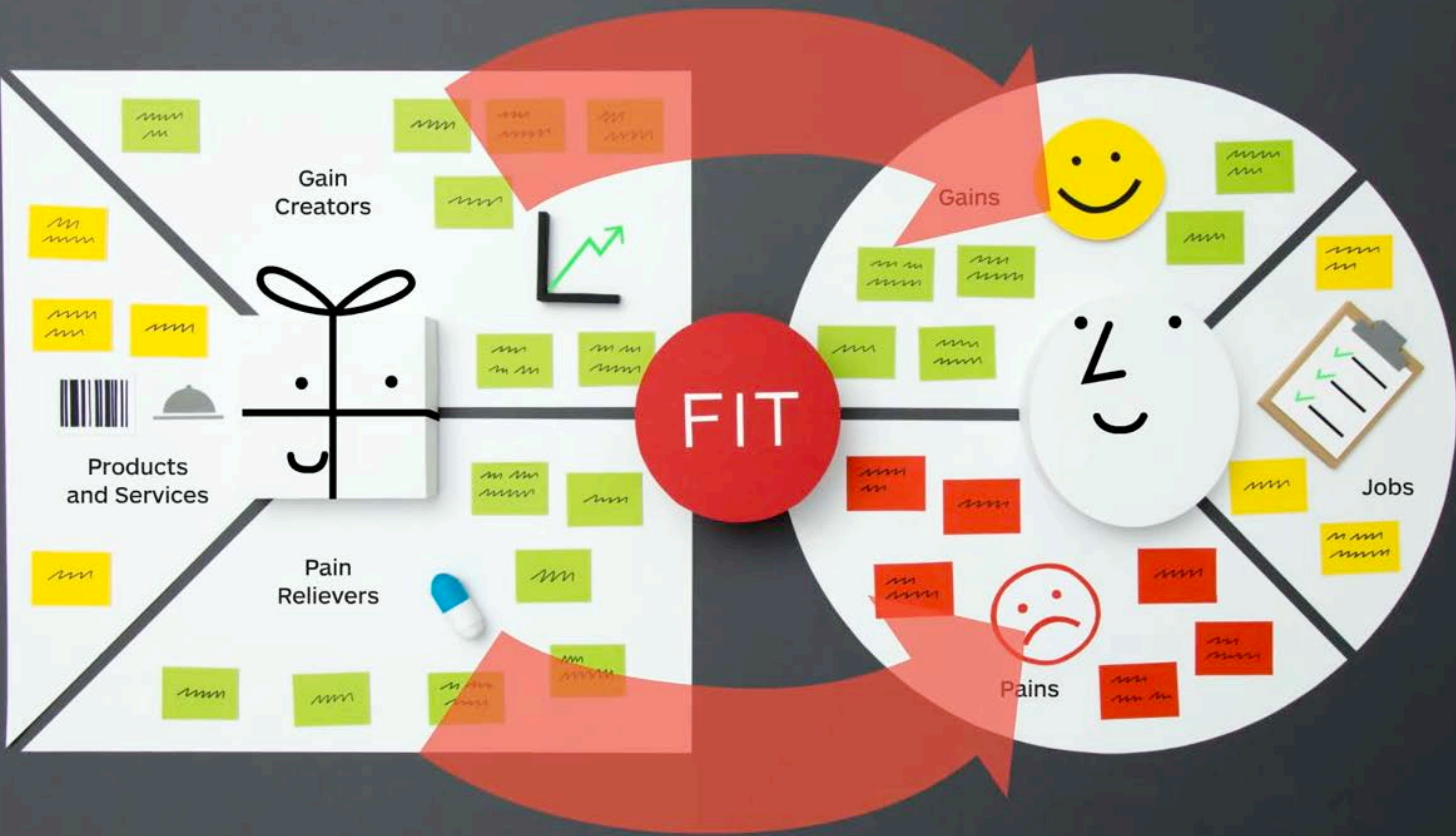


1. Does your product/ service provide savings? (Regarding time, money, efforts, etc.)
2. Does it improve the emotional state of your customer? (Decrease grief, irritation, things that bring a headache).
3. Does it fix the defects/lack of features of existing solutions?
4. Does it remove the difficulties or problems that your customer faces?
5. Does your product/ service exclude the negative social consequences that are encountered or which are afraid of your customers?
6. Does it reduce the risks that your clients are afraid of?
7. Does it help your customers sleep better at night?

Gain creators:



1. Does your product provide savings that make your client happy?
2. Does it ensure the results that the customer expects?
3. Does it simplify the work or life of the customer?
4. Does it give something that your customer wants to get?
5. Does your product/ service reflect some of the dreams of your customer?
6. Does it give positive results that meet the criteria for success and failure of the customer?







**“If you want to understand
how a tiger hunts, don’t go
to the zoo...**

Go to the JUNGLE!

-Jim Stengel

In summary

Designing a business case

- Your idea will come from **defining** and **understanding** (and solving) the user's problem(s)
- Think like an entrepreneur (and an intrapreneur)
- Innovate a product, process or business model- make it better
- What “job” is the user hiring you/your product for?
- “Walk a mile in another person's (the user's) shoes”



thank you!